



The most notable pick from other nations was Jang-Kun Lee, who is back in the Patna Pirates setup. A kabaddi veteran in South Korea, Lee is an Asian Games bronze and silver medallist and a member of a pathbreaking kabaddi generation trained by India's E. Prasad Rao. He was a member of the team that handed India its first-ever Asian Games defeat in the 2018 Jakarta Games, and became an imperious raider for the Bengal Warriors first, and the Pirates in 2019.

Over the last few years, kabaddi lost favour in the South Korean sporting setup when a new

administration took over and the existing player pool was shuffled. Lee even explored other avenues of work, taking to football, teaching kabaddi, and even acting. However, his return to the Pirates brings hope for a revival of South Korean kabaddi, which stunned the world in the past decade. Other countries represented this season include Bangladesh, Thailand, and Chinese Taipei, likely due to their performances at the 2022 Asian Games in Hangzhou last year. Sri Lanka, Kenya, England, and Poland — nations that had players in the PKL mix last season — have all dropped off this season's list.

The Bengaluru Bulls is one of the few teams that regularly rotates its foreign player pool, ensuring opportunities for one or two players to gain experience in the game and culture of kabaddi.

Changing fortunes: Sachin Tanwar (above) was the top buy of the auction, fetching ₹2.15 crore from the Tamil Thalaivas. However, Pardedeep Narwal (left), one of its most expensive players at one point, only drew a top bid of ₹77 lakh from Bengaluru Bulls.

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"We want kabaddi to be promoted. It shouldn't be limited to Iran and India. We've previously brought players from Poland, Nepal, and Bangladesh. I make different changes — one year for Iran, and another year for another country's player, and so on. I want them to learn something from me in two months," Sehrawat said.

Rao told *Sportstar* on the sidelines of last season that it's not enough for teams to sign international players and keep them rooted to the bench. "There should be playing opportunities for these players; that's the only way to truly gauge the quality of the sport in India," he explained.

